a more-than-two-year stint in Mizoram, considered a ‘hard area’ posting. After a hard stint an officer is entitled to select a posting of his or her choice. Apparently, there was, once again, no place for her. She was kept waiting compulsorily for over nine months without work. As already mentioned, it was only when such a state of affairs was objected to by the accountant general that she was quickly sent to the vacancy that existed at Tihar Jail. The Tihar post was lying vacant as no one was willing to occupy it.

Tihar Jail in the early 1990s was completely shrouded in secrecy. The entire area was closed to the outside community for fear of being exposed on how the inmates were being treated. The reality was that they were being treated like street animals. They were uncared for, disorderly and possessed a mob mentality. They were being tackled by mob management tactics. To say that the place was totally disorganized would be an understatement.

The jail staff members were typically colonial in their outlook. In her initial visits to the jail they would precede her with batons in their hands, clearing the way for the IG and barking commands. And their language? It was crude and offensive towards the inmates. The inmates would all crowd around, wondering why a senior officer had come visiting the jail. The earlier practice was to have the prisoners locked up whenever an officer visited the prison. For security reasons, the authorities claimed. There was an absolute fear psychosis prevailing. There was no communication between the IG and the prisoners. Everyone faced problems in plenty but no solutions were forthcoming because of this lack of communication. Individual attempts were made to sort out problems, but there certainly was no collective effort in this direction. As a police officer Kiran was quite used to moving amidst aggressive crowds and so she had no problems moving amidst the prisoners, although the magnitude certainly was greater. The environment posed no threats for her and she was very comfortable standing or sitting amidst large groups of prisoners to discuss their problems with them. This close contact with the inmates revealed that they were totally disorganized and disoriented. The purpose behind such meetings was not so much as to offer immediate solutions as soon as problems were stated but rather to make the staff, along with her, become aware of them. Because she had been there with them she could later ask her staff to analyse the problems that had come up in these meetings, discuss them with the prisoners and suggest collective measures to overcome them. This approach helped greatly in their participation in, and involvement with, the prevailing situation.

The word ‘inspection’ has become obsolete in prison parlance. It was suggested that the staff members try and observe the causes and consequences of their actions and to see if they had a clear conscience about what they had done. This suggestion led to a lot of introspection amongst them, and corrective measures for problems arising out of their own mistakes were freely offered. As a matter of fact, the officers were very forthcoming on the rectification of their errors. This was a very good sign and it paved the way to progress much faster than one would have thought.

‘Anger’ was the operative word for the earlier mode of action adopted by the staff. They were habituated to using force whenever they encountered any form of indiscipline. Their actions were all geared to put the fear of authority into the prisoners’ minds. They probably never even thought of trying to create respect for authority. It seemed that there were two antagonistic forces present there: the prisoners on the one side and the jail staff on the other. There was a sense of mutual distrust. Therefore, the staff probably felt that fear was the key. The entire environment exuded an aura of negativism and the culture of working towards gaining respect was nonexistent.

Kiran herself sums up the situation lucidly:

> I was quite conscious of one fact that could prove very detrimental to my efforts. I was aware